

COMMON CAUSE

Established designers tie up with retail chains to widen their base, as affordable fashion comes of age on a recession-hit ramp and bounces back into the smart street

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Between a checkered hat, a houndstooth bowler and a multi-coloured peak cap, Narendra Kumar Ahmed was wearing way too many hats at Lakme Fashion Week's Spring Summer edition. And that's not just literally. At the five-day fiesta, the designer showed three separate collections, all distinctly different. If one showcased menswear, the other two marked the designer's advent into what sartorial watchers call fast fashion—style for the masses at prices for the masses. Whether that means collaborating with mass retail chain Westside or starting an entirely new label to cater to the conscious but cash-savvy.

Ahmed wasn't the only one spreading his wings. In fact, as most of spring's couture and prêt failed to draw applause, the idea of affordable fashion seemed to be the best thing to have walked the ramp. While denim brand Levi's roped in ace couturier Tarun Tahiliani to spice things up, Westside collaborated not only with Ahmed but two emerging designers, Vivek Karunakaran and Vivek Kumar, to design clothes for people who want to look stylish but don't want to spend too much. "Everybody on the streets of Milan and Paris looks stylish because they have those clothes available. But in India it's still very difficult to find

the right fit and style within a budget," says Karunakaran, who has designed a menswear collection priced between Rs 1,200 and Rs 3,500. "The idea is to take fashion from the runway to the street," says Ahmed.

It's one of the first few brands to have taken such an initiative in India, but internationally mass retail chains collaborating with designers is a hugely popular enterprise. From Karl Lagerfeld and Stella McCartney designing capsule-collections for Target to Roberto Cavalli getting creative for H&M, numerous sartorialists have replaced their \$2,500 dresses for \$25 T-shirts. "It's the next logical step for any growing fashion industry," says Levi's Marketing Director Shyam Sukhramani. After showing his

VIVEK KUMAR FOR WESTSIDE

PRICE: Rs 1,500 and above

NUMBER OF STORES:

11 Westside stores

Kumar's evening-wear for women consists of draped dresses, tunics and tops.

NARI NARI

PRICE: Rs 1,700 and above

NUMBER OF STORES: 10

Narendra Kumar's new label takes designer wear from runway to streets.

SPENDTHRIFT

PRICE: Rs 3,500 onwards

NUMBER OF STORES: 1

Gothic and edgy are the buzzwords for Shane and Falguni Peacock's new label.



MANDAR DEODHAR

SHANE AND FALGUN PEACOCK